



The Listing Prep Checklist

How to get a home photo-ready in 48 hours

FOR REAL ESTATE AGENTS

Why this matters

Listings with professional photos sell faster and photograph better when the home is prepared. The difference between a good shoot and a great one is almost never the camera — it is the forty minutes of prep nobody did.

This checklist is what we wish every seller did before we arrive. Send it to your client when you book the shoot.

Print it, forward it, or paste it into your listing agreement. It is yours to use.

48 hours before

Every room

- Clear all countertops. Kitchen counters should hold **one** item at most
- Remove all fridge magnets, photos, kids' artwork, notes
- Take down family photos and anything with names on it — buyers need to imagine themselves living there, and it protects your seller's privacy
- Remove religious and political items
- Clear the floors. Anything that does not belong in that room goes
- Empty every waste bin
- Hide charging cables, remotes, phone chargers
- Straighten blinds so every slat runs the same direction — this shows badly in photos and is the single most common miss

Kitchen

- Counters cleared to one or two styled items
- Sink completely empty and dry
- Dish towels removed or folded neatly out of frame
- Remove soap bottles, sponges, drying racks
- Clear the stovetop entirely
- Fridge front completely bare

Bathrooms

- All personal items away — toothbrushes, razors, medication, soap
- Fresh towels, folded and matching. Mismatched towels read as clutter
- **Toilet seats down.** Every time
- Remove bath mats unless they are new
- Shower and tub cleared of bottles
- Mirrors cleaned

Bedrooms

- Beds made with the best linens in the house
- Matching pillows, no visible pilling or stains
- Nightstands cleared to a lamp and maybe one small item
- Nothing visible under the beds
- Closet doors closed
- Remove laundry baskets

Living areas

- Cushions plumped, throws folded
- Remove excess furniture. Most rooms photograph better with 20% less in them
- Coffee table styled simply — a book, a plant, nothing more
- Cords hidden behind furniture
- TV off

Outside

- Cars moved out of the driveway and off the street in front of the house
- Bins and recycling out of sight completely
- Lawn mowed, edges trimmed, leaves cleared
- Hoses coiled and stored away
- Toys, tools, and equipment put away
- Pool cleaned and cover removed
- Patio furniture arranged as though someone is about to sit down
- Front door and porch swept
- Seasonal decorations removed unless the listing goes live in that season

The morning of the shoot

- **Turn every light on** in the house, including closets and appliance lights
- Replace any burnt-out bulbs — a dead bulb shows in every photo of that room
- Use the same bulb colour throughout a room. Mixed warm and cool bulbs are very hard to correct afterwards
- Open all blinds and curtains fully
- Turn ceiling fans off. Moving blades blur
- Turn the TV off
- Pets and pet items out of sight — beds, bowls, litter boxes, toys
- Trash and recycling out of the house entirely
- Cars gone from the driveway
- Temperature comfortable — we may be there two hours

What we can fix, and what we cannot

Setting expectations here saves everyone a difficult conversation later.

We can fix in editing	We cannot fix
Grey skies, flat light	Clutter and personal items
Minor lens distortion	Dirty windows or floors
Colour balance and exposure	Burnt-out light bulbs
Small blemishes on walls	Cars in the driveway
Removing a stray cable	Damaged or stained furniture
Lawn colour to a degree	Overgrown landscaping

Editing costs time and time costs money. A prepared home means a faster turnaround and better photos, every time.

The five-minute version

If the seller only reads one thing, send them this:

1. Clear every countertop and the fridge front
2. Turn on every light, replace dead bulbs
3. Open all blinds, align the slats
4. Toilet seats down, personal items away
5. Cars out of the driveway, bins out of sight
6. Beds made, floors clear
7. Ceiling fans and TVs off
8. Pets and pet gear out of sight

Those eight items account for most of the difference between an average listing gallery and one that gets saved and shared.

One more thing — twilight shoots

If the property has good exterior lighting, a pool, or a view, ask about a twilight session. Twilight exteriors consistently outperform daytime shots as the lead image on a listing.

They need to be scheduled around sunset, so book them further ahead.

Questions about prepping a specific listing? We are happy to walk through it before the shoot. It is easier to solve on the phone than in editing.